THE VILLISCA REVIEW

XLI, NO. 46 VILLISCA, IOWA, THURSDAY, JUNE 13, 1912 EIGHT PAGES

PEOPLE MURDERED IN THEIR BEDS IN VILLISCA SUNDAY NIGHT

ily of J. B. Moore, Numbering x, and Two Daughters of Mr. and Mrs. J. T. Stillinger the Victims

TIVE FOR CRIME LACKING

ds of All Crushed With Ax, and urderer Escapes Leaving No Clue—Crime Is Unparalleled In History of State

THE DEAD:

Moore, age 43
Moore, age 39
rman Moore, age 11
herine Moore, age 10
d Moore, age 7
l Moore, age 5
a Stillinger, age 11
Stillinger, age 8

Sunday night, or early on the of Monday, June 10, 1912, was the scene of one of the dious crimes in all the his- the world. While the city ping, following a peaceful some fiend incarnate en- the home of Mr. and Mrs. J. on East Third street, and, an ax, murdered eight peo- le they slept in their beds. d are:

B. Moore, age 43.
Moore, age 39.
an Moore, age 11.
rine Moore, age 10.
Moore, age 7.
Moore, age 5.
Stillinger, age 12.
Stillinger, age 8.

first six named constitute the family of J. B. Moore, one of 's most prominent business d the head of the J. B. Moore ent company of this city. The s last named are daughters and Mrs. J. T. Stillinger, liv- rtheast of Villisca. Mr. Still- a prominent and well to do Mrs. Stillinger, who is in health, is prostrated over edy and there has been much shown over her condition. time her death was reported. and Mrs. C. C. Moore, of the dead man, are couple, the former nearly years of age, and by many it ght that the burden to them er than they can bear. Mr. practically an invalid, and to leave his home. Parents Moore are Mr. and Mrs. John ery, of north of town, and too, comes a measure of grief of a kind that but few have ever endured.



STILLINGER, age 8

No Clue to Murderer

The discovery of the crime threw the city into the wildest state of excitement, and hundreds hurried to the scene of the tragedy. Few there were who were permitted to enter the house of carnage, and few, indeed, were there who cared to. The sight was one to make the stoutest hearts quail. Down stairs, in a bed in the northwest room, lay the bodies of the two Stillinger girls, their heads chopped open with an ax, and their blood and brains presenting a spectacle so repulsive that it was almost beyond comprehension that six more victims, murdered in identically the same fashion, lay in the two bedrooms up stairs. In the north upstairs bedroom were the bodies of Mr. and Mrs. Moore, who were on their backs, apparently as they were when asleep, and in the south room, in three beds were the four children, Herman, Katherine, Boyd and Paul. There were no signs of a struggle on the part of any of the victims, except perhaps in the case of one of the girls downstairs, on whose arm a slight cut appeared. The bodies were not mutilated below the heads, and their faces had been covered up after the crime, either with part of the bedding or some discarded wearing apparel. So carefully was the deed accomplished that no where does there appear the slightest clue by which the murderer may be run to cover. The house does not present a deranged condition; there are no tell-tale blood stains leading to the door; there are no finger prints discernible on the woodwork or the doorknobs. Every door and window was locked except the two windows in the room occupied by the Stillinger girls down stairs, and the evidences there showed that they had not been used either in entering or leaving the house. A cobweb and a dead fly on the window sill in one, and a sewing machine laden with stockings and other clothing standing in front of the other, together with undisturbed flower pots outside, are ample proof of this. Although the front door to the dining room was locked there was no key to it, and the only solution of the problem of exit lies in the theory that the murderer escaped through the front door, locking it after him and taking the key with him. Before going, either before or after committing the fiendish deed, he had taken the precaution to pull down all the window curtains and to darken the doors, using an old black apron in one case and a black skirt in the other. In such condition was the house found at about half past eight o'clock Monday morning by Ross R. Moore and Mrs. Mary E. Peckham, who were first to enter and to look upon the terrible scene, so far as the downstairs portion of the house contributed to it.

Motive Is Lacking.

Not until Marshal J. H. Horton appeared upon the scene did any one attempt to go upstairs, and then the marshal, in company with Dr. J. C. Cooper and Dr. E. C. Mough, came upon the fullness of the awful tragedy, which stands without parallel in the history of civilized nations. Adding to the mystery is the utter lack of any semblance of a motive which by any stretch of the imagination could have caused the brutal crime. So far as is known J. B. Moore had no enemies; neither he nor his family nor the Stillinger girls. He had no entangling business connections; he had had no quarrel with any one. He and his family dwelt at peace with the world, and they were respected by all who knew them. Robbery was not the motive, for nothing is known to have been taken from the place. Mr. Moore's trousers hung on the bedpost, and in them were a bunch of keys, three memorandum books, a check drawn by his brother, C. A. Moore, and some money. His watch lay on the dresser down stairs in the room occupied by the Stillinger girls. In the coroner's inquest commenced Tuesday afternoon it was made a matter of record that there had been some estrangement between Mr. Moore and two of his brothers in law, Samuel Moyer and Roy Van Gilder, both of whom have absented themselves from their families for a number of years, but it is past comprehension that either of them, for any cause real or not, could have returned to Villisca, and in the dead of night, perpetrated such a foul deed solely for the sake of revenge. The relatives themselves are the last to suspect either of these men, and although the authorities in charge of the case would like very much to locate them there is very little real belief of either's guilt. More likely is the theory that some roaming madman, crazed with the lust of blood, has entered or secreted himself in the Moore home, and given vent to his unhumanly desire by murdering eight people in probably as many minutes.)



J. B MOORE, age 43



MRS J B. MOORE, age 39

Similar to Kansas Crime

A theory carrying considerable weight is that the crime was committed by the same man who murdered Rolland Hudson and wife, Anna, at Paola, Kansas, on the night of Wednesday, June 5, four days previous to the Villisca murders, the circumstances being almost identically similar. At Paola, as at Villisca, a lamp, without a globe, was found sitting on the floor. At Paola a pickax is thought to have been the instrument of death. There, as at Villisca, the motive was not robbery, for the murdered woman's diamond rings were unmolested on her fingers; and the murderer covered his retreat so carefully that not a vestige of a clew was found. The man and wife were murdered as they lay sleeping, and showed no signs of a struggle. W. J. Hobin, a newspaper man representing the Kansas City Post, who was assigned to cover the Paola tragedy, came directly from that city to Villisca, and he told The Review that to all appearances the crime at Villisca was done by the same man as that at Paola, and, upon receiving a special permit to enter the Moore home here, found the missing globe from the lamp which sat on the floor in the downstairs bedroom. Finger prints on the globe will be used as a means of identification, as will those on the ax found leaning against the wall close to the lamp. Mr. Hobin thinks the murderer at Villisca was secreted in the closet downstairs, and in support of his belief points out that a roll of cotton in a box there has been mashed down, as though sat upon, and a faint, but none the less evident, heel print impression in visible in the dust on the floor. A similar crime, in which six persons lost their lives, is reported to have occurred at Colorado Springs on the night of September 17 last, and on October 1st, William E. Dawson, his wife and daughter were slain with an ax in their home at Monmouth, Illinois. An electric flashlight, with the words, "Colorado Springs, Sept 4," was found near the Dawson home several days after the murder. Sheriff W. T. Fitzpatrick arrived from Monmouth yesterday morning, and in an interview with The Review man stated that the methods employed here and at Monmouth were exactly the same, the windows and doors being darkened in both cases, and no robbery committed.

Mr. and Mrs. William Showman and their children were found murdered in their cottage at Ellsworth, Kansas, October 15th last, and the arrest of Mrs. Showman's brother in law followed. The Colorado Springs, Monmouth and Villisca murders occurred on Sunday night, which gives some cause for thinking it may be the work of a religious maniac.

Four Arrests Made

So thorough was the work of the Villisca murderer, and so completely has the earth swallowed him up, that the authorities now are at a loss to know which way to turn. Before the arrival of the sheriff and the coroner, no one seemed in authority, and much valuable time was lost in getting after the murderer. Mayor F. L. Ingman was in the country and did not return until about noon. Word was telegraphed to Beatrice, Nebraska, for bloodhounds, and Elmer Noffsinger, owner of the famous kennels at that place, arrived with two dogs on No. 12 Monday night. Posses were formed and spread out through the country, and one man, a tramp, realizing the danger that threatened, gave himself up to the police for protection. A previous suspect had been placed in the city bastile until such time as his innocence could be proven. Tuesday morning word came from New Market that two men there, of a rather bad contenance, one slightly taller than the other, had been seen, and that they boarded a fast moving freight out of town towards Clarinda. The authorities at Clarinda were notified but the men were not apprehended. Four negroes, said to have slept down by the hand car house in the Burlington yards at Villisca for three or four nights, disappeared on the night of the murder, and no trace has been found of them Two men were taken into custody Tuesday night, but were later released after identity was established.

Work of the Dogs

Promptly upon arrival of the dogs from Beatrice, Nebraska, Monday night they were taken to the Moore home, allowed to scent the ax handle and started upon the trail of the murderer. The dogs seemed eager to go, and appeared to have a good scent although it was a matter of some eighteen or twenty hours since the trail was made. They left by the front door of the house, went off the east end of the porch, and up Sixth avenue north to Second street where they turned west going clear to First avenue in the opposite end of town. There they turned south and continued straight to John Green's farm, crossing the Green farm to the Mrs. E. A. Neillsson farm bringing up at the West Nodaway river, where they seemed to lose the scent. Taken to the other side of the river they were unbale to pick it up again, and at last were brought back to town. The next morning they were taken out to the river again, but were unable to make progress, a slight rain having dampened the scent. They were brought back to the house and given a fresh start, and again made for the river. Once they seemed to have found the trail west of the river, but it availed nothing, and after a half dozen unsuccessful attempts the chase by bloodhounds was abandoned. The dogs had followed an apparently easy scent almost to the forks of the West and Middle Nodaway but could go no farther. Near the point where the trail seemed to enter the river, a couple of dirty handkerchiefs were found, but they bore no bloodstains, and apparently one of them had been used as a target for rifle shooting. Many persons followed the dogs, in autos, on horseback or on foot, in the hope that they might get upon some kind of a clue, but they might better have saved their energies. At times the dogs crossed soft tracks of ground where no tracks were visible; at other times footprints were plainly discernible, and measurements were taken. Villisca people are divided as to the merits of bloodhounds in cases presenting no better foundation for success than did this one. One of the dogs, the small black one, was used in running down Hez Rasco, the Maryville, Missouri, murderer. They are said to have been very successful on a number of occasions. They were taken out of Villisca on No. 9 Tuesday evening.

Town is Thronged With People

Nothing that has happened since Mr. Thiele murdered his wife in Villisca twelve years ago has served to attract the attention and to hold the morbidly curious crowd as has this unparalleled crime. It is estimated that fully five thousand people gathered on the streets of the city Monday, hundreds coming from out of town, yet in all this crowd there was not the least sign of disorder or boisterous action. Every where prevaded a sense of oppression. The awfulness of the affair carried its lesson to the heart of every citizen, and each stood in respectful silence as the events of the day progressed. Groups formed and theories were discussed. Business was abandoned. Towards evening detectives and newspaper men from the cities began pouring into the town, and details of the awful tragedy were hurled to the world. Posses were formed every hour of the day; armed men scoured the country for many miles all day Monday and most of Tuesday.

Militia Are Ordered On Duty

Company F under Capt. C. J. Casey was ordered out by Sheriff O. E. Jackson, and a patrol was staitoned around the J. B. Moore home at six o'clock Monday evening to keep the curious crowds away until the dogs came to do their work. The city has been under martial law since. Gossip flew thick and fast all day Monday and took on new life Tuesday. First came the word that Roy Van Gilder had been seen again in the city, but that rumor was soon exploded. Then it was reported that Longnecker of Omaha, a private detective, had discovered a thumb print on the ax handle. This was considered of much importance. Neighbors were said to have heard dogs barking in the neighborhood of the Moore home Sunday night. They did not help the case any, however.

Heard Noises Sunday Night

Mrs. F. F. Jones thought she heard a peculiar noise in the vicinity of her home, and had Mr. Jones get up and turn on a light. This was between one and two o'clock. E. H. Landers, who is staying with his mother, Mrs. M. A. Landers, living within a block of the Moore home,

(Continued on Page 8)

CORONER'S INQUEST BEGUN

No New Facts Brought to Light and Mystery Seems Farther From Solution Than Ever—Eleven Witnesses Examined Tuesday Afternoon

County Coroner A. L Linquist of Stanton, who has been personally in charge of the investigation following the awful tragedy of Sunday night, began an inquest with a jury of three men Tuesday afternoon at half past one o'clock at the city hall, and by half past three had examined eleven witnesses, with the promise of many more to come The inquest will be held open for a day or two, and new witnesses called as the investigation progresses.

To date the work of the coroner's jury has not been productful of any particularly satisafctory results, and no new phases to the baffling mystery have been developed which will lend any clue to the identity of the murderer or the motive which prompted his fiendish act The inquest, far from bringing out anything of a tangible nature, simply served to deepen the mystery.

The coroner's jury is composed of Dr. W. A. Lomas, W. R. Finlayson and J. Y. Wickersham, the official stenographer being J. M. Johnson of Council Bluffs, who was especially engaged for the purpose. The examintion of witnesses was conducted by County Attorney W. C. Ratcliff and Coroner A. L. Linquist.

The first witness called was

Mrs. Mary E. Peckham

Mrs. Peckham stated that she had been acquainted with J. B. Moore and his family for more than thirteen years, living just next door west of them on East Third street. The distance between the two houses is not more than twenty feet, she thought. On the day before the tragedy she saw the family before church time in the evening, but not afterwards. She did not notice a light in the house, nor did she hear any unusual sounds at any time during the evening or night. She retired about eight o'clock, not feeling well, and arose Monday morning between four and five o'clock and started to do a washing. Along toward eight o'clock she felt conscious of a terrible stillness around the Moore home, and inasmuch as it was their custom to rise early she became considerably alarmed She noticed that all the curtains were down —something rather uncommon at that time of morning—and her suspicions, which at first were slight gradually deepened upon her. She went to the house, knocked on the door and tried to open it. It was locked. The horses in the stable were acting restless and the chickens were cheeping with hunger, and the cow was unmilked. Mrs. Peckham returned home and called up Ross Moore's residence, and asked Mrs. Moore if there was anything the matter down to the C. C. Moore home, or if Father Moore was sick, adding a statement as to the conditions existing at the J. B. Moore residence. Then she called E. F. Selley, who is an employe of J. B. Moore, at the store, and asked him to come up and feed the horses and

(Continued on Page 8)

Developments Up to Midnight

A man aged about 56, height 5 feet, 9 inches, with iron gray hair and mustache, shoes No. 9, with low heels, wearing a dark coat, light gray hat, and yellow overalls was arrested in a school house south of Essex Monday, but was released through a misunderstanding. The man's overalls had blood stains on the right leg. His nose is very red and he is red under the eyes. He was recaptured last night about 3 1-2 miles south of Emerson, and is in jail at Emerson. Word that he was headed toward Red Oak caused an excited crowd to gather there last evening. U. S. Deputy Harrison Kelso with Ray Huey and Guy Robinson were to a point about two miles south of Emerson last night, within two miles of the point where the man was taken.

Word that a man, bareheaded and without a shirt, was seen going down the Nodaway river in a boat caused a scurry among the officers and detectives last night and telegrams were sent to the towns of Skidmore, Nodaway, Burlington Junction, Quitman, Napier, Bigelow and Forest City, Missouri, by County Attorney W. C. Ratcliff asking that a close watch be kept for such a character. If the murderer escaped in a boat it would be in keeping with the results obtained by the bloodhounds, who followed a trail to the river and then lost it. The information was brought to the attention of the detectives by Mrs. Myrtle Kunse of Clarinda, who was visiting in Villisca Tuesday. Mrs. Kunse stated that John Smith of Clarinda, a peddler of mite medicine, had said that he had seen the man. Smith verified the statement over the phone last night.

A suspicious character, giving the name of Joe Rick, was arrested at Monmouth, Illinois, yesterday. He is reported to have admitted being in Villisca, but later denied it. There was blood on his pants and on his shoes. He is about forty years of age, five feet, nine inches tall, weighs about 185 pounds, has small gray eyes. Sheriff W. T. Fitzpatrick of Monmouth, who was here on the two cases, left for Monmouth immediately.

Two detectives left yesterday morning for Nehawka, Nebraska, upon information that Samuel Moyer was in that city, and over the telephone to Sheriff O. E. Jackson stated that they had seen Moyer and that they were convinced that he was in Nehawka at the time of the murder. If this is true it effectually eliminates any suspicion that might have attached itself to Moyer.

A stranger is said to have stopped Fay Van Gilder near the high school last Saturday and to have asked her a number of peculiar questions. He is described as a short, heavy set man, wearing a dark suit.

(Continued on Page 8)



LENA STILLINGER, age 11